

Galatians, Part 2

Galatians 3–6 | Grace, freedom, and life in the Spirit

SERIES QUESTION What problem is being addressed, and how does the gospel answer it?

BIG IDEA Those justified by faith are free to live by the Spirit in love rather than return to slavery.

Follow the argument

PASSAGE	PAUL’S MOVEMENT
Galatians 3:15–29	The law did not cancel God’s earlier promise. Christ is Abraham’s promised Seed; all who belong to Christ are Abraham’s offspring and heirs.
Galatians 4:1–31	God sent his Son and Spirit to make slaves into children and heirs. Hagar and Sarah illustrate slavery contrasted with promise and freedom.
Galatians 5:1–26	Stand firm in Christ’s freedom. Faith works through love, and the Spirit produces a life the flesh cannot create.
Galatians 6:1–18	Life in the Spirit becomes gentle restoration, shared burdens, persevering goodness, boasting in the cross, and new creation.

Key terms

- Promise — God’s pledged blessing to Abraham, fulfilled in Christ and shared by all who belong to Christ.
- Law — God’s instruction to Israel; it exposed and confined sin and served as a guardian until Christ, but it could not justify or give life.
- Freedom — release from seeking justification through law and from the domination of sin, so that believers may serve one another in love.
- Flesh — fallen, self-directed human life resisting God; it does not mean the physical body is inherently evil.
- Walk by the Spirit — active dependence on the Spirit who gives life and forms Christlike character and community.

Look closer

ABRAHAM’S SEED “Seed” can refer to one descendant or a collective family. Paul centers the promise in Christ; people united to Christ share his identity as Abraham’s offspring and heirs.

THE YOKE Many Jewish people viewed Torah as a gracious gift. Paul’s objection is not that God’s law was evil, but that circumcision and law were being imposed on Gentiles as necessary for justification and full belonging.

Freedom is not either ditch

NOT THIS	BUT THIS
Religious self-justification	Stand in the freedom Christ has already won.
Self-indulgence	Serve one another humbly in love.
A private virtue checklist	Keep in step with the Spirit in a burden-bearing church.
Boasting in identity or achievement	Boast in the cross; what counts is new creation.

The Gospel Then and Now

CHURCH REALITY THEN Gentile believers were tempted to seek secure status through circumcision and law; the churches also faced rivalry, division, and self-indulgence.

CHURCH TEMPTATION NOW We can seek assurance through performance or call self-centeredness “freedom,” while excusing anger, rivalry, division, or harm.

GOSPEL-SHAPED CHURCH Because Christ has set us free and given the Spirit, the church serves in love, restores gently, carries burdens, perseveres in goodness, and boasts only in the cross.

Discuss

1. What has Christ freed us from—and what has he freed us for?
2. How can a church make obedience the fruit of grace rather than the price of belonging?
3. Which works of the flesh can hide behind respectable church behavior?
4. What would gentle restoration and burden-bearing look like in practice?

For further study

ECO CONNECTION Essential Tenets III.A: God’s grace in Christ; III.C: covenant life in the church; III.E: living in obedience to the Word of God. eco-pres.org/constitution/

READ MORE ONLINE BibleProject, Book of Galatians Guide: bibleproject.com/guides/book-of-galatians/

CLASS RESOURCES & UPCOMING LESSONS

keithbreuer615.github.io/pauls-letters-class/



BEFORE NEXT WEEK START HERE: Read Acts 17:1–10 and 1 Thessalonians 1. **CONTINUE IF POSSIBLE:** Read 1 Thessalonians 2–3. Notice how the gospel was received under pressure and what Paul praises in the church.